fairly stable and efficient part of the EU. It is also a fast growing market for the Western member states, a source of a relatively cheap and qualified workforce, as well as considerable capital gains from foreign investments.

More and more, this part of Europe is now also making its own contribution to the foreign and security policies of Europe – even if the region's approach to Russia was, until the Russian invasion of Ukraine, not appreciated in the West and its sensitivities and fears perceived in Brussels as overblown. 'Here Slovenia was a step ahead of us,' a Finnish diplomat wrote to me in response to my congratulations on Finland's decision to enter NATO in the spring of 2022.

Indeed, under Polish-Baltic leadership, NATO has decided to strengthen its eastern flank, as the war in Ukraine has helped to bring Central Europe more to the centre of the attention of the international community and the West in particular, including again the United States. The case of Ukraine may even affect the whole concept of EU enlargement. We will probably see more geopolitics discussed in relation to Ukraine and Moldova (a country too often forgotten), as well as with the Western Balkans.

More mixed is, as this book acknowledges, the region's record on the political and governance side. Ruling parties in Poland and Hungary have now for years been accused of capturing the state with a socially conservative, populist or outright illiberal and fundamentalist ideology. Even in the otherwise traditionally liberal and pro-Western Czech Republic, both current President Zeman (his term expires in 2023) and former Prime Minister and magnate Babiš (in office from 2017 to 2021) have been blamed for populist tendencies. In neighbouring Slovakia, the political and judicial system was shaken to the core by the murder of an investigative journalist Ján Kuciak in 2018 and by the struggle of the system to bring the killers (and those that ordered the execution) to justice. In Slovenia, three consecutive elections (2014, 2018 and 2022) propelled to the post of Prime Minister political novices, so-called new faces. There, as in some other instances, the capture of the state and populism is believed to have a different ideological character. To add to this are the region's controversial reaction to the migrant crisis of 2015/2016 and the reluctance of some of the countries to embrace certain aspects of the so-called LGBT+ agenda, understood now as an essential part of the new generation of human rights.

Does all this mean that a distinct version of Europe, an illiberal Europe, is